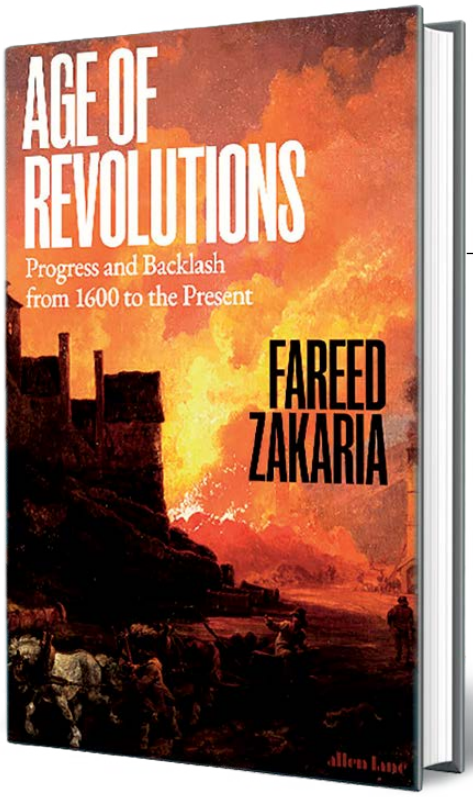


AGE OF REVOLUTIONS Progress and Backlash from 1600 to the Present *by Fareed Zakaria*
ALLEN LANE
₹1,299; 400 pages

Fareed Zakaria stands out even among the numerous success stories of Indian immigrants in the US for his reputation as a columnist, an author and a television anchor. This is not because he is interpreting developments in India or Asia for First World audiences. He may do that occasionally, but his success is unusual because despite his first-generation immigrant origin Zakaria occupies the elevated perch of construing developments in the US and Europe for Americans and Europeans.

This is in so many ways both an inversion of the traditional stereotypes of how the West views the Occident, as a vindication of the overall success of the US as a nation-state in general and of its policy of assimilation.

Yet a deep concern about the future of the US and the way of life that underwrites its success story so far permeates *Age of Revolutions* and has motivated it. 'The future of America in an age of Trump' can easily, if somewhat simplistically, be summarised as its principal theme.

In a conversation with this reviewer, Zakaria explained that what he was investigating was not simply an American predicament but meant "grappling with a broader phenomenon", not just in the West but also in Turkey, Brazil and India, with different variants of populism. "I realised that this was the rise of something very powerful—in a sense an assertion against liberal, urban educated elites who had been charge for the past four or five decades," he said.

Understanding these processes meant a deep dive into the history of political, technological and societal change and the backlash it generates. The initial chapters are thus a compressed tutorial about change through revolutions in the Netherlands, in England, in France and in the US. This historical survey is to set the background for Zakaria to address the grand question that interests him: the domestic and geopolitical consequences of change in all its dimensions.

The answers are seemingly obvious, but he dwells on these at some length: change breeds and provokes its own reaction and therefore progress and the reaction against it go together. The subtitle—'Progress and Backlash from 1600 to the Present'—sums this up. The second idea Zakaria explores is how societal and political polarisations evolve and mutate. The old left-right binaries that so dominated the 19th and most of the 20th century have now been superseded. Western societies today confront their most intense divisions not over economics or welfare issues but over the politics of identity, immigration, abortion rights and the like, and it is these issues that drive political manifestos and narratives.

Zakaria's main argument centres around the rapid

BOOKS

ONE TONGUE, MANY VOICES

In this book of essays, Rakhshanda Jalil shines a light on the inclusive and pluralistic nature of Urdu poetry

Shiva's body is "like a glittering sapphire", he is "knowledge, nectar, action", the "Granter of Salvation": these encomiums appear in three different Urdu poems. "Written by both Muslim and non-Muslim poets at a time when inclusion and pluralism were the norm rather than the exception, these need to be revived and re-read not merely for their evocations of communal harmony and goodwill, but also because much of it is simply good poetry," writes Rakhshanda Jalil, in her new compilation of essays, *Love in the Time of Hate: In the Mirror of Urdu.*

While Urdu poetry might be commonly associ-